

THE MARTINI AT Upstairs arrives looking austere—pale, served without ornament, in a classic V-shaped glass. Hinting towards its secret ingredient, that is more likely to be found simmering in a pot than swirling inside a cocktail glass: bone marrow.

For Varun Sharma, Head of Bars, EHV International, that opened Upstairs in December right above Indian Accent in New Delhi, the drink was never conceived as a gimmick. It was an attempt to distil the restaurant's culinary philosophy into liquid form.

"While designing the menu, I wanted to do a cocktail which was very Indian yet global, an ode to the cuisine served at Indian Accent," says Sharma. The resulting Bone-Dry Martini, made with bone marrow-washed vodka, *nihari*-spiced vermouth (made in-house) and smoked tamarind, took more than 90 days and an entire crate of spirits to perfect. "We tried it with everything—from cognac to whisky—and finally settled on vodka and a martini."

The cocktail is a collaboration between kitchen and bar, using the left-over bone marrow from the restaurant's signature *nihari*. More importantly, it reflects a larger shift underway in contemporary drinking culture. "People are more experimental now. They are not drinking cocktails to get drunk, they just want to try more flavours," says Sharma.

Increasingly, the boundaries between the pantry and the back bar are dissolving.

That blurring of lines is evident at Top Banana in New Delhi, where chef Tarannum Sehgal, founding chef and brand lead, Top Banana (Bright Hospitality) and beverage head Sushil Pant devised an unlikely martini featuring fish sauce to celebrate World Martini Day. Although never formally added to the menu, it quickly developed a following among guests who have been requesting for it by name.

"It's a psychological fact that once the brain tastes salt, it wants another sip or another bite. The whole idea of adding fish sauce to the drink, for me, was like opening a packet of salted Lays. You can't stop eating. You take a sip, and you want another," says Sehgal.

The success of the drink depended not on amplifying fishiness but disguising it. Sehgal credits Pant's technical skill for

transforming an ingredient associated with Southeast Asian kitchens into something elegant and deeply drinkable.

"We've taken a leap beyond savoury, now we are actually deep diving into umami," wwshe says.

She believes today's drinkers are increasingly willing to embrace these layered flavours because they have travelled, eaten more adventurously, and witnessed the evolution of cocktail culture around the world. The result is an audience that is just as comfortable ordering bacon, fermented ingredients or fish sauce as it is requesting a perfectly executed Bloody Mary.

For Jeet Rana, Co-Founder of Barbet & Pals in GK's M-Block market, the conversation never revolves around novelty for its



1. Upstairs' Bone Dry Martini

2. Top Banana's martini featuring fish sauce